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Original Page: 73**Culture (OWC):** [San \(FX10\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Southern Africa**Field Date:** 1958-1964**Coverage Date:** Ca. 1958-1964**Place Coverage:** G/Wi San, Botswana**Section Title(S):** (2) Status Of Members. • (3) Esteem.

There are no chiefs or headmen and every adult member of the band has rights equal to those of all the other members to reside in the band's territory and to make use of what is found in it in the way of food or materials for tools, weapons, housing, clothing, etc. In the regulation of the band's affairs, none has any more authority than any other by reason of superior status and, except for the obligations within his or her kinship group toward senior kin (children to parents, step-parents, etc.), no man or woman yields to the superior authority of any other member.

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(3) *Esteem.*

One must distinguish clearly between status and esteem. Status is the value attached to a person's office, regardless of the manner in which he fills it, by the social stratum he occupies, while esteem depends on his conduct in that office or stratum. Thus a doctor has a higher status than does a nurse, but the nurse—by excellent performance of her duties — may be held in very much higher esteem than an unpopular, inept doctor.

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While there are no status differences between adults in G/wi bands, there are significant variations in the degree of esteem in which members stand in different fields of activity. A particularly good hunter will be respected as such and when the band is discussing hunting matters, his opinions will carry more weight than those of less gifted hunters. However, when some other problem is under discussion, this man's words might well be ignored. Prestige in one field does not necessarily confer esteem in other aspects of the band's life.

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Esteem is not only a matter of ability in a particular activity, but is also a function of personality and character. The ideal personality combines a quiet but friendly manner, cheerfulness, kindness and consideration for others, generosity, decisiveness, energy and a readiness to join in group activities. Cleverness expressed in ingenuity is a desirable trait, but must never take the form of scoring off somebody else for one's own gain. Wit is also admired, for the G/wi have a keen sense of the ridiculous and greatly enjoy comedy of situation. Their well-developed sense of humour allows even the discomfited target of wit to get a certain amount of wry enjoyment out of the situation, and this ability to stand a joke is a favourable characteristic.

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Excessive self-confidence is regarded as an unpleasant quality, and the loud, domineering type is not admired at all. A quick temper, inclination to surliness or sulkiness, sarcasm, dishonesty, cruelty and laziness are strongly disapproved of and the display of any of these faults ■ 74 detracts from an individual's prestige and lessens his influence and standing among his colleagues of the band. Any disposition to violence is shameful in the extreme and would take a lot of living down.

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